

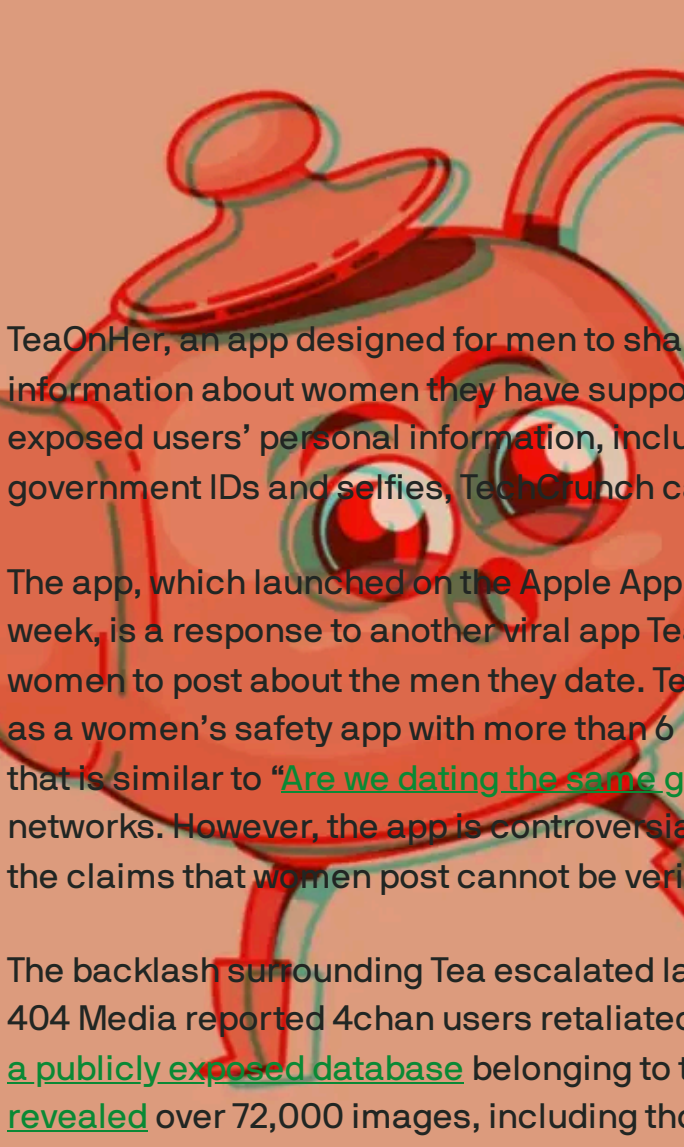
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SECURITY



# A rival Tea app for men is leaking its users' personal data and driver's licenses

Amanda Silberling, Zack Whittaker



TeaOnHer, an app designed for men to share photos and information about women they have supposedly dated, has exposed users' personal information, including government IDs and selfies, TechCrunch can confirm.

The app, which launched on the Apple App Store earlier this week, is a response to another viral app Tea that allows women to post about the men they date. Tea is advertised as a women's safety app with more than 6 million users that is similar to "[Are we dating the same guy?](#)" Facebook networks. However, the app is controversial, since many of the claims that women post cannot be verified.

The backlash surrounding Tea escalated last week, after 404 Media reported 4chan users retaliated by [discovering a publicly exposed database](#) belonging to the app, which [revealed](#) over 72,000 images, including thousands of selfies and photo IDs submitted for account verification. A [subsequent hack](#) exposed more than 1 million private messages sent over the app, prompting the app to [disable](#) its messaging feature.

TeaOnHer, which is now ranked No. 2 among Lifestyle apps on iOS, appears to be a direct rebuttal to the Tea app, even copying the language from Tea's App Store description in its own listing.

But like the app it sought to emulate, TeaOnHer contains security flaws of its own.

TechCrunch has found at least one security flaw that allows anyone access to data belonging to TeaOnHer app users, including their usernames and associated email addresses, as well as driver's licenses and selfies that users uploaded to TeaOnHer. Images of these driver's licenses are publicly accessible web addresses, allowing anyone with the links to access them using their web browser.

In one case, TechCrunch saw a list of posts shared on TeaOnHer appended with each user’s email address, display name, and self-reported location.

TechCrunch is withholding some of the details of the bugs so as to not help malicious actors access anyone’s data. The app’s maker did not respond to emails from TechCrunch asking who we can report the flaws to. As such, TechCrunch is publishing this report with limited details of the issue, given the app’s current popularity and the risk faced with using the app.

TeaOnHer was uploaded to the iOS App Store by a developer named Newville Media Corporation. According to LinkedIn, the founder and CEO of this company is Xavier Lampkin.

TechCrunch identified at least one TeaOnHer record associated with Lampkin’s own data.

The security lapse will likely affect any user who signed up or shared identity documents with the app. The bug also exposes the number of users the TeaOnHer app has, which is about 53,000 users at the time of publication.

TechCrunch also identified a potential second security issue, in which an email address and plaintext password belonging to the app’s creator, Lampkin, was left exposed on the server. The credentials appear to grant access to the app’s “admin” panel. TechCrunch did not use the credentials, as doing so would be unlawful, but highlights the risks of inadvertently leaving admin credentials exposed to the web.

Along with its security flaws, the content portrayed within TeaOnHer is troubling in itself. While the app requests IDs and selfies from its users to verify their identities — a process that is not automatic — users can access a “guest” view of the app without signing in.

Immediately upon opening “guest” view, TechCrunch saw several images of the same naked woman, posted under different names in a form of spam. It is not clear if this woman consented to this photo being shared. Other posts share the photos and names of women, alongside

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comments calling them “easy,” or accusing them of spreading sexually transmitted infections.

Across all free apps, TeaOnHer is ranked No. 17, higher than apps like Instagram, Netflix, Uber, and Spotify. Tea is currently ranked No. 2.

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**Amanda Silberling**

Senior Writer |

Amanda Silberling is a senior writer at TechCrunch covering the intersection of technology and culture. She has also written for...

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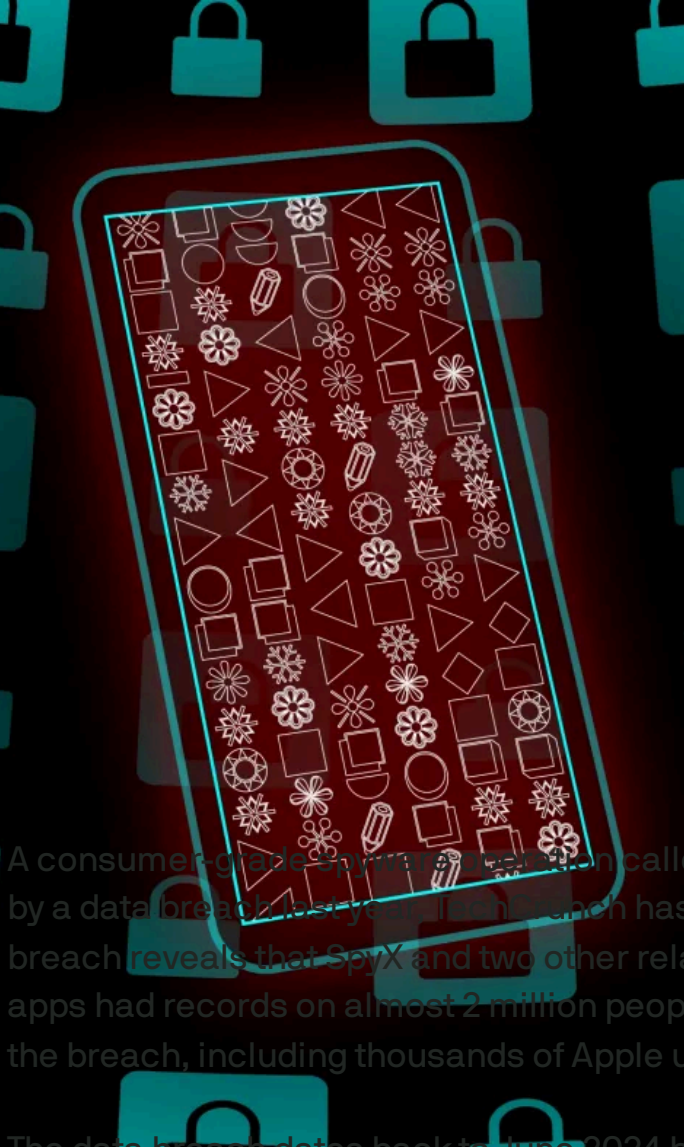
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# Data breach at stalkerware SpyX affects close to 2 million, including thousands of Apple users

Zack Whittaker — 3:30 PM PDT · March 19, 2025

A consumer-grade spyware operation called SpyX was hit by a data breach last year, which Crunch has learned. The breach reveals that SpyX and two other related mobile apps had records on almost 2 million people at the time of the breach, including thousands of Apple users.

The data breach dates back to June 2024 but had not been previously reported, and there is no indication that SpyX's operators ever notified its customers or those targeted by the spyware.

The SpyX family of mobile spyware is now, by our count, [the 25th mobile surveillance operation since 2017](#) known to have experienced a data breach, or otherwise spilled or exposed their victims' or users' data, showing that the consumer-grade spyware industry continues to proliferate and put people's private data at risk.

The breach also provides a rare look at how [stalkerware](#) like SpyX can also target Apple customers.

Troy Hunt, who runs data breach notification site [Have I Been Pwned](#), received a copy of the breached data in the form of two text files, which contained 1.97 million unique account records with associated email addresses.

Hunt said the vast majority of the email addresses are associated with SpyX. The cache also includes less than 300,000 email addresses associated with two near-

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identical clones of the SpyX app called Msafely and SpyPhone.

About 40% of the email addresses were already in Have I Been Pwned, Hunt said.

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As with previous spyware breaches, Hunt marked the SpyX data breach in Have I Been Pwned as “sensitive,” which allows only the person with an affected email address to see if their information is part of this breach.

The operators behind SpyX did not respond to emails from TechCrunch with questions about the breach, and a WhatsApp number listed on SpyX’s website returned a message saying it was not registered with the messaging app.

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# Another spyware, another breach

SpyX is billed as mobile monitoring software for Android and Apple devices, ostensibly for granting parental control of a child's phone.

Surveillance malware, like SpyX, also goes by the term [stalkerware](#) (and spouseware) because sometimes the operators explicitly promote their products as a way to spy on a spouse or domestic partner, which is broadly illegal without that person's knowledge. Even when the operators don't explicitly promote this illegal use, spyware apps share much of the same stealthy data-stealing capabilities.

Consumer-grade spyware, like stalkerware, usually works in one of two ways.

Apps that work on Android devices, including SpyX, are typically downloaded from outside of the official Google Play app store and require someone with physical access to a victim's device — usually with knowledge of their passcode — to weaken its security settings and plant the spyware.

Apple has stricter rules about which apps can be on the App Store and run on iPhones and iPads, so stalkerware usually taps into a copy of the device's backup found on Apple's cloud storage service, iCloud. With a person's iCloud credentials, stalkerware can continuously download the victim's most recent backup directly from Apple's servers. iCloud backups [store the majority](#) of a person's device data, including messages, photos, and app data.

According to Hunt, one of the two files in the breached cache referred to iCloud in its filename and contained about 17,000 distinct sets of plaintext Apple Account usernames and passwords.

Since the iCloud credentials in the breached cache clearly belonged to Apple customers, Hunt sought to confirm the authenticity of the data by reaching out to Have I Been Pwned subscribers whose Apple Account email addresses and passwords were found in the data. Hunt said several

people confirmed that the information he provided was accurate.

Given the possibility of an ongoing risk to victims whose account credentials might still be valid, Hunt provided the list of breached iCloud credentials to Apple prior to publication.

Apple did not comment by press time when reached by TechCrunch prior to publication.

In a brief statement provided after publication, Apple spokesperson Sarah O'Rourke told TechCrunch: "When data breaches at other companies pose a risk to Apple accounts, our security teams work to rapidly investigate and protect our users. In this case, fewer than 250 iCloud users were impacted, and we immediately secured their accounts."

As for the rest of the email addresses and passwords found in the breached text files, it was less clear if these were working credentials for any service other than SpyX and its clone apps.

Meanwhile, Google pulled down a Chrome extension linked to the SpyX campaign.

"Chrome Web Store and Google Play Store policies clearly prohibit malicious code, spyware and stalkerware, and if we find violations, we take appropriate action. If a user suspects their Google Account has been compromised, they should take [recommended steps](#) immediately to secure it," Google spokesperson Ed Fernandez told TechCrunch.

## How to look for SpyX

TechCrunch has a [spyware-removal guide for Android users](#) that can help you identify and remove common types of phone-monitoring apps. Remember to have [a safety plan in place](#), given that switching off the app may alert the person who planted it.

For Android users, switching on [Google Play Protect](#) is a useful security feature that can help to protect against



Android malware, including unwanted phone surveillance apps. You can enable Google Play from the app's settings if it isn't already enabled.

Google accounts are far more protected with [two-factor authentication](#), which can better protect against account and data intrusions. Know [what steps to take if your Google account is compromised](#).

If you have an iPhone and iPad, you can check and [remove any devices from your account that you don't recognize](#).

You should ensure that your Apple account uses a long and unique password ([ideally saved in a password manager](#)) and that your account also has [two-factor authentication switched on](#). You should also change your iPhone or iPad passcode if you think someone may have physically compromised your device.

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*If you or someone you know needs help, the National Domestic Violence Hotline (1-800-799-7233) provides 24/7 free, confidential support to victims of domestic abuse and violence. If you are in an emergency situation, call 911. The [Coalition Against Stalkerware](#) has resources if you think your phone has been compromised by spyware.*

*Updated with comment from Apple.*

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Zack Whittaker is the security editor at TechCrunch. He can be reached via encrypted message at zackwhittaker.1337 on Signal, o...

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IMAGE CREDITS: RAW

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# Dating app Raw exposed users' location data and personal information

Zack Whittaker — 10:56 AM PDT · May 2, 2025

A security lapse at dating app Raw publicly exposed the personal data and private location data of its users, TechCrunch has found.

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The exposed data included users' display names, dates of birth, dating and sexual preferences associated with the Raw app, as well as users' locations. Some of the location data included coordinates that were specific enough to locate Raw app users with street-level accuracy.

Raw, which launched in 2023, is [a dating app](#) that claims to offer more genuine interactions with others in part by asking users to upload daily selfie photos. The company does not disclose how many users it has, but its app listing on the Google Play Store notes more than 500,000 Android downloads to date.

News of the security lapse comes in the same week that the startup announced a hardware extension of its dating app, the Raw Ring, an [unreleased wearable device](#) that it claims will allow app users to track their partner's heart rate and other sensor data to receive AI-generated insights, ostensibly to detect infidelity.

Notwithstanding the [moral and ethical issues of tracking romantic partners](#) and [the risks of emotional surveillance](#), Raw claims on its website and in its privacy policy that its app, and its unreleased device, both use [end-to-end encryption](#), a security feature that prevents anyone other than the user — including the company — from accessing the data.

When we tried the app this week, which included an analysis of the app's network traffic, TechCrunch found no evidence that the app uses end-to-end encryption. Instead, we found that the app was publicly spilling data about its users to anyone with a web browser.

Raw fixed the data exposure on Wednesday, shortly after TechCrunch contacted the company with details of the bug.

"All previously exposed endpoints have been secured, and we've implemented additional safeguards to prevent similar issues in the future," Marina Anderson, the co-founder of Raw dating app, told TechCrunch by email.

When asked by TechCrunch, Anderson confirmed that the company had not performed a third-party security audit of its app, adding that its "focus remains on building a high-

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Amanda Silberling,  
Zack Whittaker  
- 12 hours ago

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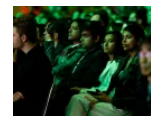


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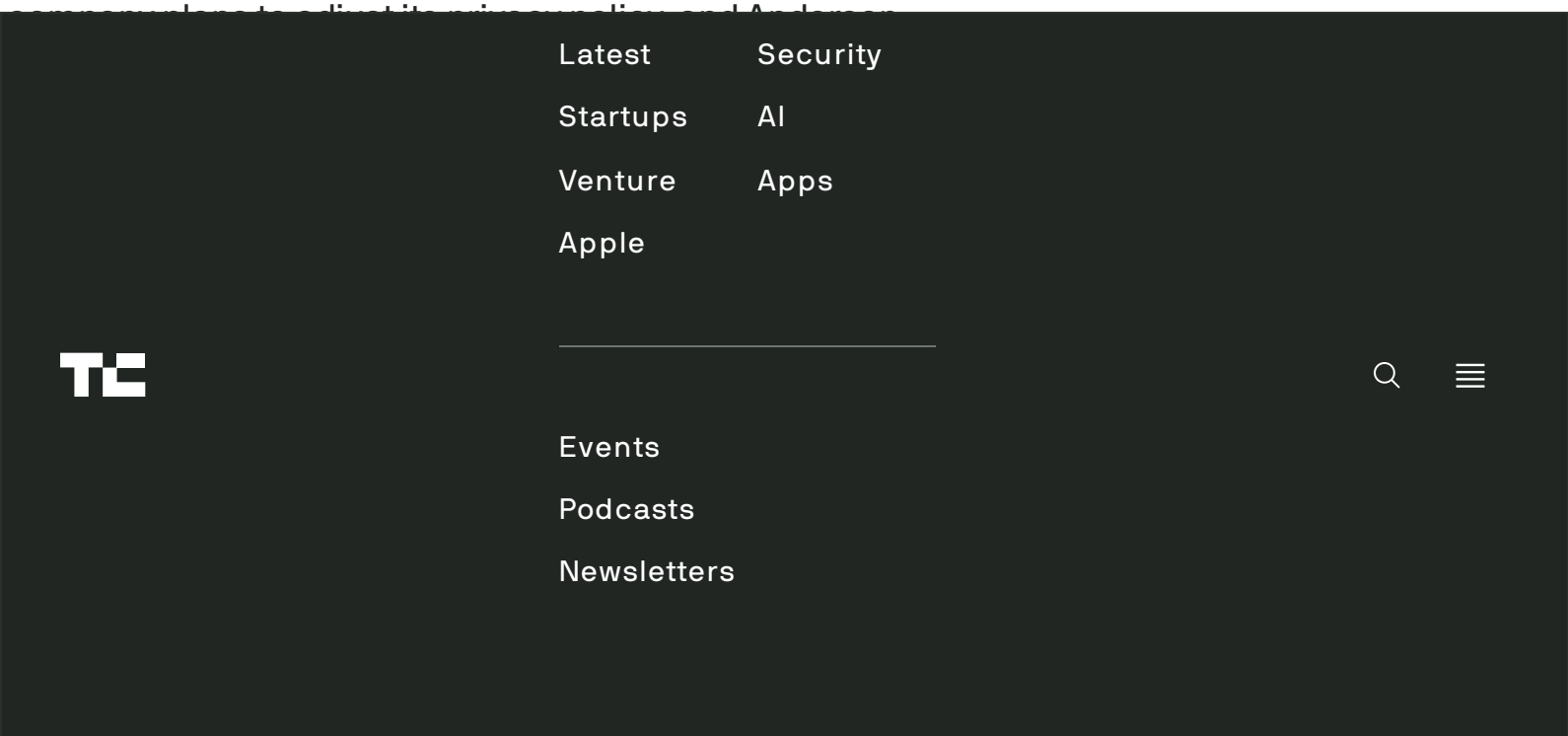
quality product and engaging meaningfully with our growing community.”

Anderson would not commit to proactively notifying affected users that their information was exposed, but said the company would “submit a detailed report to the relevant data protection authorities under applicable regulations.”

It’s not immediately known how long the app was publicly spilling its users’ data. Anderson said that the company was still investigating the incident.

Regarding its claim that the app uses end-to-end encryption, Anderson said Raw “uses encryption in transit and enforces access controls for sensitive data within our infrastructure. Further steps will be clear after thoroughly analyzing the situation.”

Anderson would not say, when asked, whether the



in mountain view, California when the app requested our virtual device’s location, we allowed the app access to our precise location down to a few meters.

We used a network traffic analysis tool to monitor and inspect the data flowing in and out of the Raw app, which allowed us to understand how the app works and what kinds of data the app was uploading about its users.

TechCrunch discovered the data exposure within a few minutes of using the Raw app. When we first loaded the

app, we found that it was pulling the user's profile information directly from the company's servers, but that the server was not protecting the returned data with any authentication.

In practice, that meant anyone could access any other user's private information by using a web browser to visit the web address of the exposed server — `api.raw.app/users/` followed by a unique 11-digit number corresponding to another app user. Changing the digits to correspond with any other user's 11-digit identifier returned private information from that user's profile, including their location data.

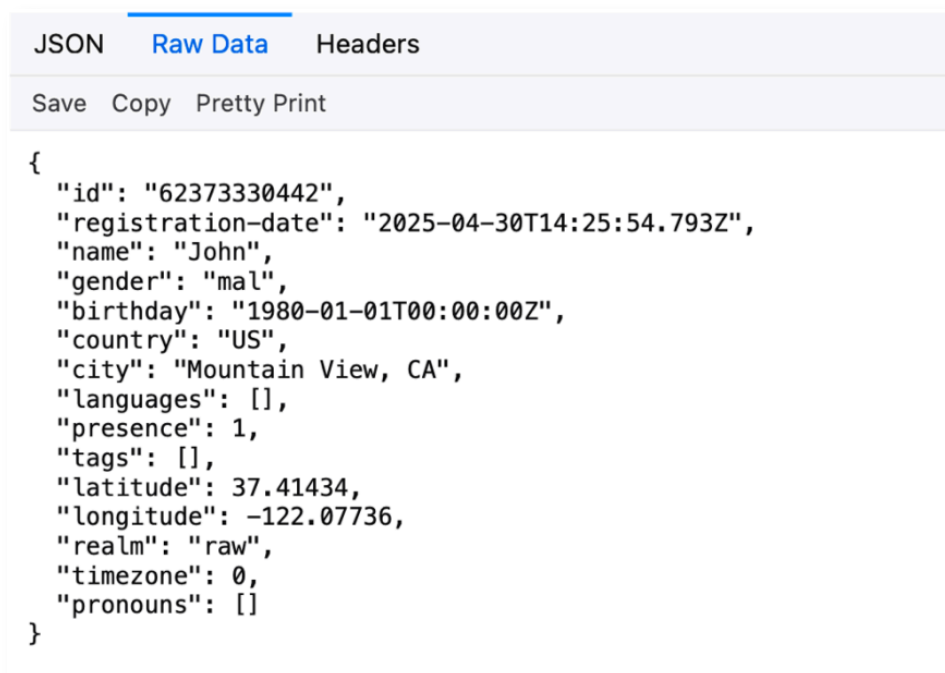


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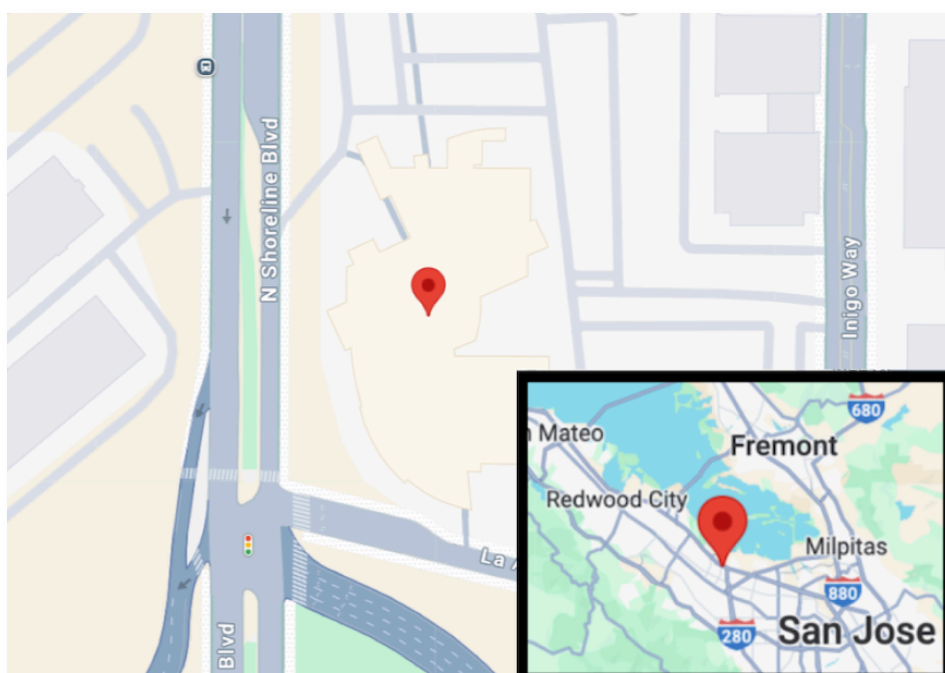


IMAGE CREDITS: TECHCRUNCH

This kind of vulnerability is known as an insecure direct object reference, or IDOR, a type of bug that can allow someone to access or modify data on someone else's server because of a lack of proper security checks on the user accessing the data.

As [we've explained before](#), IDOR bugs are akin to having a key to a private mailbox, for example, but that key can also unlock every other mailbox on that same street. As such, IDOR bugs can be exploited with ease and in some cases enumerated, allowing access to record after record of user data.

U.S. cybersecurity agency CISA has long warned of the risks that IDOR bugs present, including the ability to access typically sensitive data "at scale." As part of its [Secure by Design](#) initiative, CISA said [in a 2023 advisory](#) that developers should ensure their apps perform proper authentication and authorization checks.

Since Raw fixed the bug, the exposed server no longer returns user data in the browser.

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**Zack Whittaker**

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Zack Whittaker is the security editor at TechCrunch. He can be reached via encrypted message at zackwhittaker.1337 on Signal, o...

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# Elon Musk switched on X calling by default: Here's how to switch it off

The new X calling feature can hurt your privacy

Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai,  
Zack Whittaker

3:40 PM PST · March 4, 2024

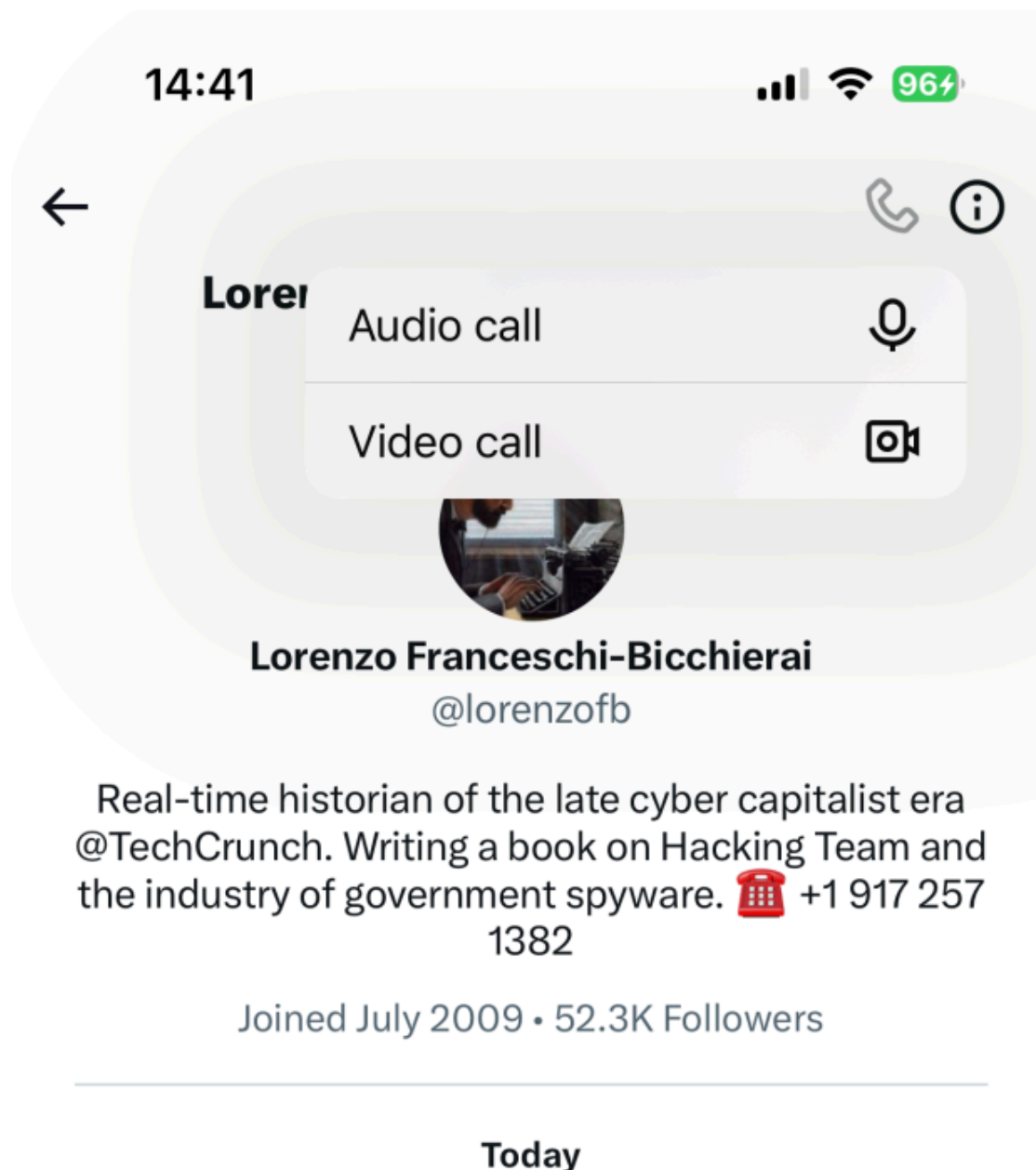
In his quest to turn a simple and functioning Twitter app into X, the everything app that doesn't do anything very well, Elon Musk launched audio and video calling on X last week — and this new feature is switched on by default, it leaks your IP address to anyone you talk with, and it's incredibly confusing to figure out how to limit who can call you.

In a post on Wednesday, X's official news account [announced the new feature](#): “audio and video calling are now available to everyone on X! who are you calling first?” X wrote.

We looked at X's official help center page and ran tests of the feature to analyze how the calling feature works and to understand the risks associated with it.

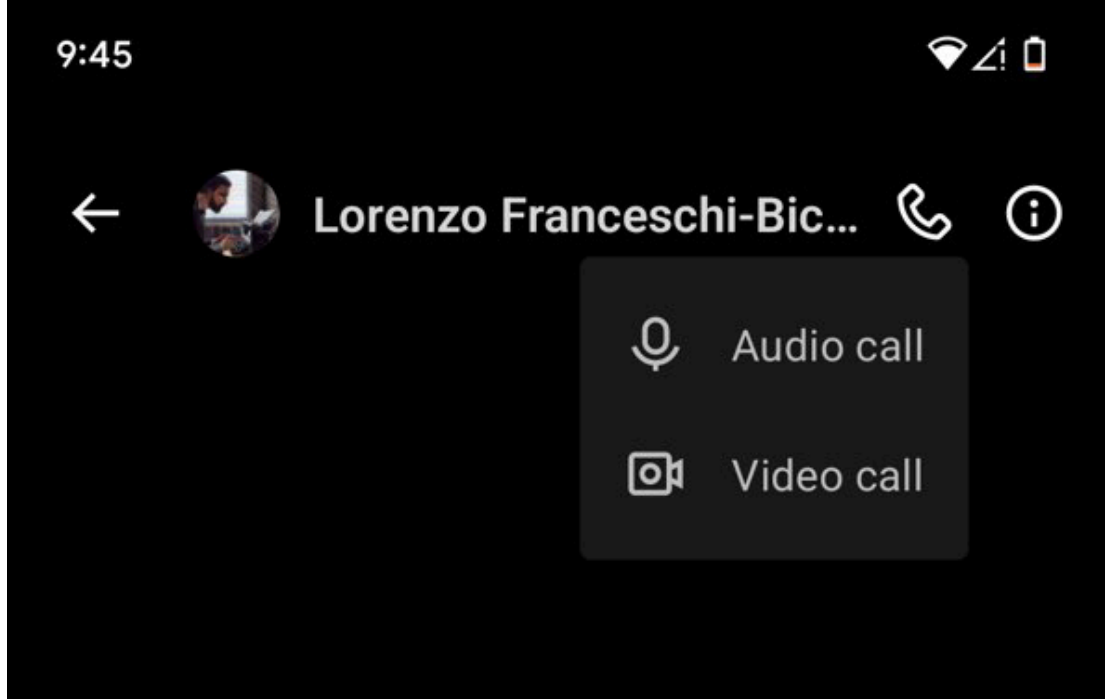
A person's IP address is not hugely sensitive, but these online identifiers can be used to infer location and can be linked to a person's online activity, which can be dangerous for high-risk users.

First of all, the audio and video calling feature is inside the Messages part of the X app, where a phone icon now appears in the top right-hand corner, both on iOS and Android.



Real-time historian of the late cyber capitalist era  
@TechCrunch. Writing a book on Hacking Team and  
the industry of government spyware. 📞 +1 917 257  
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A SCREENSHOT OF X'S AUDIO AND VIDEO CALLING FEATURE ON IOS. IMAGE CREDITS:  
TECHCRUNCH



A SCREENSHOT OF X'S AUDIO AND VIDEO CALLING FEATURE ON ANDROID. IMAGE CREDITS: TECHCRUNCH

Calling is enabled by default in the X apps. The caveat is that you can only make and receive calls on X's app, and not yet in your browser.

By default, calls are peer-to-peer, which means that the two people in a call share each others' IP addresses because the call connects to their devices directly. This happens by design in most messaging and calling apps, such as FaceTime, Facebook Messenger, Telegram, Signal, and WhatsApp, [as we reported in November](#).

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In [its official help center](#), X says that calls are routed peer-to-peer between users in a way that IP addresses “may be visible to the other.”

If you want to hide your IP address, you can turn on the toggle “Enhanced call privacy” in X’s Message settings. By switching on this setting, X says the call “will be relayed through X infrastructure, and the IP address of any party that has this setting enabled will be masked.”

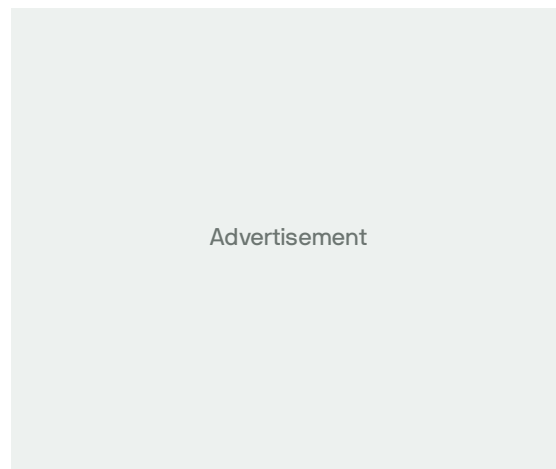
A SCREENSHOT OF THE SETTINGS FOR X'S AUDIO AND VIDEO CALLING FEATURE FOR ANDROID.

IMAGE CREDITS: TECHCRUNCH

X doesn't mention encryption in the official help center page at all, so the calls are probably not end-to-end encrypted, potentially allowing Twitter to listen in on conversations. End-to-end encrypted apps, Signal or WhatsApp — prevent anyone other than the caller and the recipient from listening in, including WhatsApp and Signal.

We asked X's press email whether there is end-to-end encryption. The only response we got was: "Busy now, please check back later," X's default auto-response to media inquiries. We also emailed X spokesperson Joe Benarroch but did not hear back.

Because of these privacy risks, we recommend switching off the calling feature completely.



In case you do want to use this call feature, it's important to understand who can call you and who you can call — and depending on your settings, it can get very confusing and complicated.

The default setting (as you can see above) is “People you follow,” but you can choose to change it to “People in your address book,” if you shared your contacts with X; “Verified users,” which would allow anyone who pays for X to call you; or everyone, if you would like to receive spam calls from any *rando*.

TechCrunch decided to test several different scenarios with two X accounts: a newly created test account and a long-standing real account. Using open source network analysis tool Burp Suite, we could see the network traffic flowing in and out of the X app.

Here are the results (at the time of writing):

When neither account follows each other, neither account sees the phone icon, and thus neither can call.

When the test account sends a DM to the real account, the message is received but neither account sees the phone icon.

When the real account accepts the DM, the test account can then call the real account. And if nobody picks up, only the test account caller's IP is exposed.

When the test account starts a call and the real account picks up (which exposes the real account's IP address — so both sets of IP addresses), the test account cannot call back because the test account is set to allow incoming calls for “follow” only.

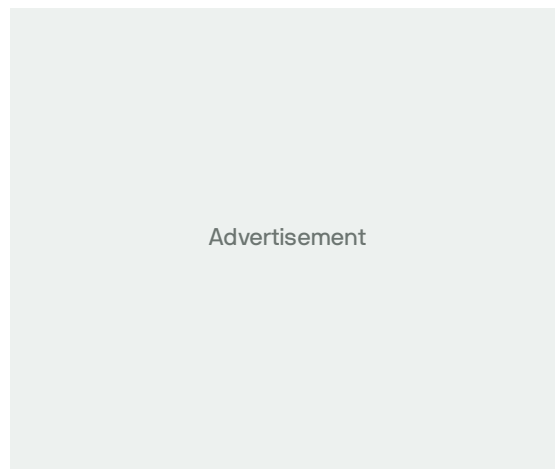
When the real account follows the test account back, both can contact each other.

The network analysis shows that X built the calling feature using Periscope, Twitter's livestreaming service and app [that was discontinued in 2021](#). Because X's calling uses Periscope, our network analysis shows the X app creates the call as if it were a live Twitter/X broadcast, even if the contents of the call cannot be heard.

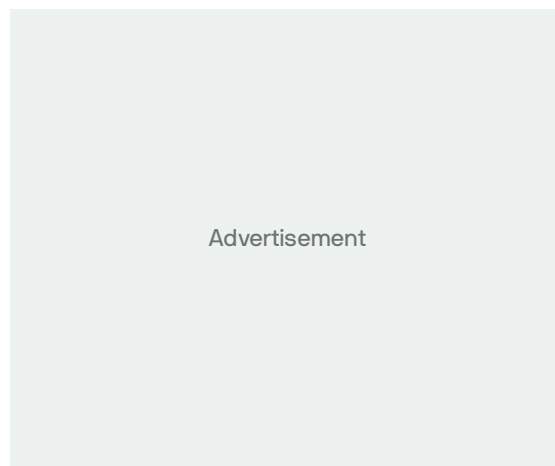
Ultimately, whether to use X calling is your choice. You can do nothing, which potentially exposes you to calls from people you probably don't want to get calls from and can compromise your privacy. Or you can try to limit who can call you by deciphering X's settings. Or, you can just switch off the feature altogether and not have to worry about any of this.

*Carly Page and Jagmeet Singh contributed reporting.*

[How to keep your Twitter secure without giving Elon Musk any money.](#)



Topics: [cybersecurity](#) [ip address](#) [privacy](#) [Security](#) [Twitter](#) [X](#)





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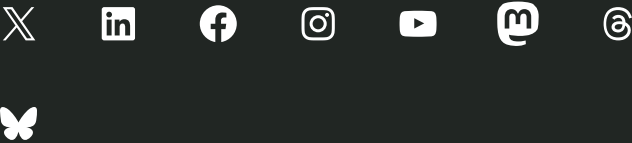
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